

Harmonics

A harmonic is a division of the zodiac into a number of mini-zodiacs. The system forms an important foundation for Vedic astrology. John Addey popularised this idea in Western astrology.

Basic principle

The core idea is that you divide the zodiac circle of 360 degrees into an equal number of parts. Each part is then treated as a new zodiac: the harmonic zodiac.

If you divide the zodiac by four, you get four parts of 90 degrees each. These 90-degree segments each represent a complete zodiac. This means that one degree in any of the four parts corresponds to four degrees of the regular zodiac.

In principle, any number can be used as a harmonic. In Vedic astrology, the 9th harmonic — the Navamsha — is of particular importance. David Hamblin and David Cochrane, among others, apply numerological principles to interpret the various harmonics.



Calculation

The calculation of a harmonic is straightforward: you take the harmonic number and multiply the longitude of all celestial points by that number.

An example for harmonic 9: if Mercury is at 2° 30' Leo, its longitude is 112° 30'. Multiplied by 9, this gives 1018° 270', or 1022° 30'. Subtracting two times 360 degrees yields 302° 30', or 2° 30' Aquarius.

Usually the calculation is limited to celestial points and often the MC and Ascendant. Calculating the harmonics of house cusps produces odd results: the multiplication causes positions to appear in the wrong order.



Fractional harmonics

Whole numbers are most commonly used for harmonics. Some authors also use fractional numbers (numbers with a decimal component). In principle, you can also calculate the harmonic for, say, 33.456. However, this no longer represents a division of the zodiac into smaller zodiacs — a remainder is left over.



Harmonics and midpoints

Both the Hamburg School and the Ebertin method make use of horoscope charts of 90°, 45°, and sometimes smaller. These are in fact also harmonics — harmonic 4 and harmonic 8 respectively.



References

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